



Comeback loading: Shivpal Singh, who was the undisputed No. 2 behind Neeraj Chopra in the Indian pecking order prior to the emergence of Manu, Rohit and Jena in the last couple of years. RITU RAJ KONWAR

seemed to disappear after he was tested positive for a banned substance late in 2021.

"That ban was the toughest time for me. I was shocked how it happened. It changed the way people saw me. They would talk behind my back; I would find that out later. I fell into depression. I avoided meeting people. And no one wants to be around you at that time," Shivpal recalls. He would fight the case and

eventually prove that his positive result was caused by a tainted supplement. Although his suspension would be reduced to one year on appeal, it was only in 2023 that he would get the all-clear to return to competition.

While he had hoped to qualify for the Asian Games, Shivpal said the long layoff did take its toll. "Honestly, I didn't want to have anything much to do with sport for a long time. And when you take a long break from the sport, it has an effect on your body. I was in the best shape of my career at the Olympics; I was around 91kg then. By the time I returned to training, after I knew that the doping ban was removed, I was 105kg. When

I started to train again, I couldn't even run 400m on the track without catching my breath," he says.

Shivpal is realistic about his physical condition at the end of the 2023 season. "I was at my peak in 2021 before the Olympics. Right now I would say that I'm at about 60 percent of where I was. I'm still about 95kg. I still have some time to get back to my peak," he says.

Despite this, he isn't short of self belief. An unexpected bonus of his long layoff was the fact that his chronic back and shoulder injuries got the time to heal. Upon his return, he found himself throwing over 80 meters with ease. Him consistently throwing above 80m despite being